

The essay

Argue your position with evidence

Word count ~400 words (360-440)	Register Formal	Title Required	Structure ~5 paragraphs
---	---------------------------	--------------------------	-----------------------------------

STRUCTURE AND LAYOUT

Title — clear and relevant - not necessarily catchy
Introduction — ~80 words - hook + state your opinion clearly
Body paragraph 1 — ~80 words - bullet point 1
Body paragraph 2 — ~80 words - bullet point 2
Body paragraph 3 — ~80 words - bullet point 3
Conclusion — ~80 words - summarise + restate opinion in different words

DO'S AND DON'TS

DO

- Write in a formal style throughout
- Make your opinion clear from the introduction
- Start each paragraph with a topic sentence
- Use generalisations, not personal anecdotes
- Use formal linking words: However, Nevertheless, Moreover, Furthermore
- Vary sentence length - mix short and long
- Use complex grammar: passive voice, conditionals, relative clauses
- You may mention a counter-argument - but then refute it

DON'T

- No contractions (don't, can't, it's)
- No colloquial or slang expressions
- No overly emotional language
- No personal anecdotes as your main evidence ("When I was 12...") - argue with general or hypothetical examples; a brief personal example is fine
- No over-generalisation ("All politicians are liars.")
- No simple linking words as your only connectors (and, but, because)
- No very short sentences one after another
- No statistics without context

WEAKER VS. STRONGER

WEAKER

Social media has many advantages and disadvantages for young people today.

STRONGER

For teenagers, the real cost of social media is not screen time. It is a slowly shrinking attention span.

Why it matters. A strong essay opens each paragraph with one clear, arguable point. The weaker version lists everything and commits to nothing, so the examiner cannot follow your line of argument.

KEY TIP

Key tip. An essay should make the reader think. It is fact-based and formal. An article should make the reader feel. An essay uses generalisations; a blog uses personal anecdotes.

USEFUL PHRASES

Giving your opinion (without overusing "I")

- It is widely believed that...
- One can argue that...
- Many people are convinced that...
- For many people,...
- It is often argued that...

When you do use "I"

- In my opinion/view,...
- I am inclined to believe that...
- I (firmly) believe that...
- I am (not) convinced that...

Adding arguments

- Furthermore,...
- Moreover,...
- In addition to this,...
- What is more,...
- Not only... but also...

Introducing the other side

- One should, nevertheless, consider...
- The other side of the coin is that...
- On the other hand,...
- Admittedly,...

Conclusions

- Taking these points into consideration,...
- All of this points to the conclusion that...
- On balance, we can safely say that...
- The arguments presented prove that...

MODEL TEXT

The Hidden Cost of Fast Fashion (~400 words · Formal · actual count 408)

Have you ever stopped to think about where your clothes actually come from? The fashion industry has grown dramatically over the past two decades, and by the mid-2010s the average shopper was already buying around 60% more clothing than in 2000. In my opinion, the environmental and social damage caused by fast fashion far outweighs the benefit of cheap clothing.

To begin with, the environmental impact of fast fashion is severe. The production of cheap garments requires enormous amounts of water and energy, and releases toxic chemicals into rivers and soil. According to the United Nations Environment Programme, the fashion industry is responsible for an estimated 2 to 8 per cent of global greenhouse gas emissions, alongside a significant share of industrial water pollution. Furthermore, a large share of these garments is worn only a handful of times before ending up in landfill. In addition, synthetic fabrics such as polyester are made from fossil fuels and shed tiny microplastics with every single wash. These particles flow into rivers and oceans, and have even been detected in human blood.

Equally alarming are the working conditions in the factories that produce these clothes. Workers in countries such as Bangladesh and Cambodia are often forced to work twelve-hour shifts for wages that barely cover basic living costs. The Rana Plaza factory collapse in 2013, which killed over 1,100 garment workers, exposed the dangerous reality behind bargain-priced T-shirts. Despite promises of reform, investigations continue to reveal unsafe conditions. Independent researchers have also uncovered widespread child labour and the violent suppression of trade unions. While shoppers in Europe enjoy an endless supply of cheap outfits, the people who actually make them are denied safety, a living wage and basic security.

Admittedly, some argue that fast fashion makes trendy clothing accessible to people who cannot afford designer brands. While this may be true to some extent, it does not justify an industry built on exploitation and pollution. Affordable clothing can exist without disposable clothing. A number of clothing brands have shown that durable, fairly produced garments do not have to be expensive.

Taking these points into consideration, it is clear that the true cost of fast fashion is paid not by consumers, but by workers and the planet. If we genuinely want to address the climate crisis, we must start by rethinking our relationship with the clothes we wear. Consumers can make a genuine difference by buying less and repairing what they already own.

WHAT THE EXAMINER NOTICES IN THIS MODEL

The marked features, in reading order:

Rhetorical question hook — *“Have you ever stopped to think about where your clothes actually come from?”*

Thesis - opinion stated clearly — *“In my opinion, the environmental and social damage caused by fast fashion far outweighs the benefit of cheap c...”*

Topic sentence (Point) — *“To begin with, the environmental impact of fast fashion is severe.”*

Evidence introducer — *“According to the United Nations Environment Programme”*

B2 linking word — *“Furthermore,”*

Evidence developed in detail — *“synthetic fabrics such as polyester are made from fossil fuels”*

Relative clause - adds detail elegantly — *“which killed over 1,100 garment workers,”*

B2 contrasting linker — *“Despite”*

Contrast carries the argument — *“While shoppers in Europe enjoy an endless supply of cheap outfits”*

Counter-argument acknowledged — *“Admittedly,”*

Counter-argument refuted — *“While this may be true to some extent,”*

Conclusion linker — *“Taking these points into consideration,”*

Conditional - complex structure — *“If we genuinely want to address the climate crisis,”*

Concrete call to action — *“buying less and repairing what they already own”*

More online. This text type also has a second model text on the website (*“Should smartphones be banned in schools?”*, ~400 words · formal) and an annotated “honest model” that shows a realistic borderline text. matura.bernhardgmeiner.com